

Unfortunately for Missouri, a complex tangle of personalities and politics stirred up a hornet's nest. The state's governor, Claiborne F. Jackson, was a staunch secessionist and did everything in his power to deliver the state for the Confederacy. Opposing him were Francis P. Blair Jr., of the politically important Blair family, and Captain Nathaniel Lyon, U.S. Army, who commanded the U.S. arsenal at St. Louis. Lyon was vigorous and aggressive, warning Jackson, "Rather than concede to the State of Missouri ... the right to dictate to my Government ... I would see ... every man, woman, and child in the State, dead and buried." Anti-immigrant feeling among some Missourians worsened matters, as German settlers formed the bedrock of Republican and Unionist support in St. Louis.

Lyon effectively ended Jackson's schemes to support secession and chose to go on the offensive in May 1861 by capturing a secessionist militia camp called Fort Jackson near St. Louis. The militiamen surrendered peacefully, but violence broke out afterwards in the city itself, and it quickly took on ethnic overtones. Lyon's measures outraged some moderate Unionists and pushed them into the secessionist camp. While Lyon swiftly crushed Jackson and his allies in the state legislature, small groups of Confederate guerrillas, or "bushwhackers," would plague the state for the rest of the war.

Lyon, who was promoted to general in July 1861, was killed during the Confederate victory at the Battle of Wilson's Creek the following month, and meaningful Southern defiance would be crushed at Pea Ridge in March 1862. This made the resistance of Confederate guerrillas strategically insignificant, but it was cold comfort for the civilians who had to cope with the chaos of a fierce and brutal civil war, triggered in part by overly aggressive reactions by Missouri's Union leaders in 1861.

The ferocious guerrilla war in Missouri produced the notorious James brothers (Jesse and Frank), Confederate "bushwhackers" from Clay County.